Special Issue Article

International Area Studies Review
2023, Vol. 26(1) 40–54
© The Author(s) 2023
Article reuse guidelines:
sagepub.com/journals-permissions
DOI: 10.1177/22338659221151129
journals.sagepub.com/home/ias

ASEAN, COVID-19 and Myanmar crisis: Dealing with critical juncture

I Gede Wahyu Wicaksana, Demas Nauvarian, and Putu Shangrina Pramudia
Department of International Relations, Universitas Airlangga, Surabaya, Jawa Timur, Indonesia

Abstract
Explaining how international institutions develop is the significant contribution of historical institutionalism (HI) to the study of contemporary world politics. HI offers two important concepts, critical juncture and path dependence, demonstrating dynamics within the institution, leading towards continuity and change. The case of the Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN) during the COVID-19 pandemic and the Myanmar democratic crisis tells us about the impact of the crucial moments on the regional organisation and its responses. Yet, ASEAN is resistant to change. What makes it possible is the question that cannot be answered by using the HI approach. Hence, we explain by employing a theoretical framework founded upon the link between diplomatic culture and institutional legitimacy, adopted from the English School (ES) theory of International Relations (IR). This article argues that ASEAN's diplomatic culture ensures member countrie's compliance with the Association's code of conduct and prevents external power intrusion into Southeast Asian affairs and interests. Therefore, ASEAN's institutional legitimacy can be maintained. The Association deals with the critical juncture without undertaking any fundamental change.

Keywords
ASEAN, critical juncture, COVID-19, Myanmar crisis, diplomatic culture, institutional legitimacy

Introduction

Since its independence in 1948, Myanmar has been one of the Southeast Asia's most volatile political entities. The former state of Burma has undergone several decades of internal instability, mainly characterised by conflict between its civil and military factions. Political instability and democratisation were the reasons and challenges for Myanmar's admittance into the Association

Corresponding author:
I Gede Wahyu Wicaksana, Department of International Relations, Universitas Airlangga, Surabaya, Jawa Timur, 60286, Indonesia.
Emails: wahyu.wicaksana@gmail.com; wahyu.wicaksana@fisip.unair.ac.id

of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN) in 1997. Myanmar's inclusion resulted from ASEAN's first stance towards the destabilised state, which was considered a gamble for some. However, scholars such as Cook (2010), Pradhan (2008) and Renshaw (2013) have argued that the embrace of Myanmar was part of ASEAN's 'constructive engagement' strategy to the unstable state. Supported by the ASEAN founding countries like Indonesia, Malaysia, the Philippines and Thailand, constructive engagement focused on engaging Myanmar to make the latter compliant with the group's code of conduct. In addition, ASEAN tried to build a safe and stable Myanmar to secure the Southeast Asian region. Consequently, during its early years in ASEAN, the military Junta government of Myanmar was given chances and rewards in exchange for democratic promises while ASEAN was bargaining for it.

Nonetheless, the constructive engagement strategy lasted only for a short time. ASEAN began to take a firmer stance towards Myanmar, shifting to an approach mentioned by Haacke (2005) as 'flexible engagement' and 'enhanced interaction'. ASEAN engaged more actively and put peer pressure on some domestic cases deemed urgent. According to Hanung and Judhistari (2021), the shift in ASEAN's Myanmar policy was a means of strengthening mechanism and a product of the changing interpretation of ASEAN's non-interference principle – a norm of interaction within ASEAN that has been blamed for disrupting its progressivity for years. The strengthening mechanism to deal with Myanmar was a way to forge a one ASEAN community and was based on the commitment of some members in promoting human rights values. ASEAN seemed to be willing to break its vagueness on the fields which were considered necessary. It is worth visiting Katanyuu's (2006) argument on what catalysed this sign of change, to which the individual members' security concerns, the group consensus, and international pressure mattered in directing ASEAN's role in the reconciliation process in Myanmar. But, it is important to note that ASEAN has never directly intervened in the Myanmar political crisis: although the tunes were louder, no real action was taken to democratise the Junta-led state of Myanmar.

When the second military coup happened in February 2021, ASEAN's role in Myanmar's democratic crisis faced severe challenges, primarily due to the COVID-19 pandemic. The situation was more critical and damaging than ever before, with the alarming impact of the public health problem on every sector, affecting each country in the region. Ruland (2021) notices that COVID-19 has accelerated the democratic decline in some Southeast Asian nations. The ruling elites lead the process of undermining political institutions that work to support the existing democracy. Individual liberties are being taken away by COVID-19, while the security forces have expanded their powers. Governments in Southeast Asia securitise the coronavirus by presenting it as a security threat rather than a health issue. More importantly, Ruland (2021) emphasises that the military uses coronavirus-related troubles to increase its political position. It is also a popular narrative within the local media that civilian authorities could not manage the complex challenges. ASEAN's responses to the political crisis in Myanmar, threats to economic growth, and COVID-19 variants are in a manner that is consistent with past instances of crisis management and governed by the 'ASEAN Way'.

Ruland's analysis demonstrates the merit of a historical institutionalism (HI) approach to assess ASEAN's institutional development. It employs two conceptual features of HI, path dependence and critical juncture, arguing that the patterns of ASEAN's COVID-19 response reinforces ideas and rules which have underpinned the establishment of the Association and maintain its stability as a regional organisation. Indeed, ASEAN has shown resistance to forces of and pressures for change during the COVID-19 pandemic and crisis in Myanmar (emphasis added). In line with the case of ASEAN, International Relations (IR) scholars have acknowledged, adopted and adapted HI's concepts and methods to the study of continuity and change in regional and global multilateral institutions (see, for instance, Rixen et al., 2016). But, despite its relevance, HI still

needs to completely address the question of what makes continuity or change possible. We aim to close the knowledge gap by proposing the concepts of diplomatic culture and institutional legitimacy to construct our theoretical framework. We refer to the English School (ES) theory of IR to develop our analytical tools and cover the weakness of the HI in explaining how institutions like ASEAN can deal with critical juncture moments of the COVID-19 and Myanmar crises without change. So, our study is built upon an eclectic HI and ES theoretical framework.

The main argument of our study is that ASEAN's diplomatic culture matters in preventing the disastrous consequences of the critical juncture on the institutional legitimacy of the Association. Two mechanisms are feasible. First, ASEAN's diplomatic culture keeps all member countries' commitment to comply with ASEAN's norms of internal relations. Second, ASEAN's diplomatic culture enables the Southeast Asian states to protect their common interests from the damaging effects of extra-regional power intrusion. With this in mind, it is understandable that ASEAN states do not undertake any significant change in their regional organisation's response to the unsettled situation. The discussion of this argument is organised as follows. After this introduction, the second section presents the theoretical framework explaining how diplomatic culture works to maintain institutional legitimacy following a critical juncture. Parts three, four, and five employ the theoretical framework to explain furthermore the case of ASEAN. The third and fourth sections explore what happened to ASEAN at the unsettled time. It is followed by the fifth section, which analyses the effectiveness of ASEAN's diplomatic culture's mechanisms to secure the Association's legitimacy. The article concludes by summarising the main findings and contribution of our study.

Critical juncture, diplomatic culture and institutional legitimacy

We introduce our new theoretical framework in this section. The meaning of critical juncture is related to the broader passage of institutional development, which is characterised by path-dependent behaviour. Path dependence is when a choice, decision or event increases returns to particular past ideas or rules, founding and stabilising the institution. Hence, path dependence is a self-reinforcing process which confines the prospect of an alteration (David, 2007). Path dependence remains significant even though the initial situation creating the institution is no longer affecting it. Within the long periods of path dependence, if a short-term flux of external events occurs and mandates a fundamental change, it is a critical juncture interrupting the institution's stability (Capoccia, 2015; Capoccia and Kelemen, 2007). Critical juncture as a turning point informs dynamism in the institution and stresses the long-term impact of agential factors on the institution's continuity and change. However, during a critical juncture, different scenarios of institutional development can arise, yet the erstwhile structural circumstances do not necessarily determine their types and directions (Rixen and Viola, 2015). Historical institutionalists confirm that the crucial moment directs the organisation to the path-dependent process (Mahoney, 2001).

Looking at the institutional development of ASEAN through the abovementioned HI lenses will encounter a series of critical junctures and returns to the initial ideas and rules having formed and preserved the regional organisation. For instance, the civil war in Cambodia and the end of the Cold War were two exogenous events having substantial weight on ASEAN. ASEAN government leaders were warned of the need for change. As a result, they enlarged ASEAN membership to embrace the volatile Cambodia and Myanmar, aiming to stabilise Southeast Asia by socialising the new members with the group's norms and values. In response to the Asian Financial Crisis in 1997/1998 and political turmoil shaking some member states, ASEAN committed to constructing a security community that would deal with non-traditional security problems as its shared concern. Nonetheless, the foundational ideas, principles and practices endured and were even

more institutionalised in the signing of the ASEAN Charter. The latest health crisis of COVID-19 and Myanmar's political conflict present ASEAN with various options for institutional change, including the revision of the Charter and reinterpretation of how the state-centric sovereignty norms-based interaction must be adapted to improve ASEAN's collective action on such crucial challenges (Amaya and De Lombaerde, 2021; Muhibat, 2021; Paulsen, 2021). ASEAN makes attempts to mitigate the consequences of critical situations. But, it always decides to rely on the old and established normative infrastructure governing ASEAN's regional roles.

There is a missing part of the story of ASEAN's decision to keep running on its traditional ground, upholding the importance of state sovereignty over individual or societal interests and placing the organisation's stability at the expense of transnational security governance. To discover the lost connections, the authors combine the HI analysis framework with ES concepts of diplomatic culture and institutional legitimacy. ES scholarship provides appropriate conceptual instruments to understand the working of regional organisations, which are the formal shapes of regional societies of states. ES scholars point out that the operation of a society of states is supported by a set of 'habits and practices shaped towards the realisation of common goals' (Bull, 1977: 74). Bull (1977: 4) then mentioned the three most important objectives to keep up: survival, compliance with agreements and protection of belongings, suggesting an order-driven activity. Diplomatic culture is one of the foundational habits and practices supporting a society of states to build its order. Others include the balance of power, international law, great power management and war (Bull, 1977). Advancing Bull's insight, Southeast Asianists like Quayle (2013) have added nationalism, economic development, and sovereignty, besides diplomatic culture, as primary habits and practices among ASEAN nations. They are operationalised in ASEAN's treaties and regional bodies. For this article, we consider that diplomatic culture, among others, is the most relevant to discuss in the episodes of COVID-19 and the latest Myanmar democratic issue in ASEAN.

We relate diplomatic culture's favourable functions to maintaining institutional legitimacy so that ASEAN can avoid change. Bull (1977: 204) defined diplomatic culture as 'the common stock of ideas and values possessed by the official representatives of states'. Bull's definition of diplomatic culture showcases the ES understanding of the concept, where scholars of the school argue that diplomatic culture develops alongside the constitution of an international society. Therefore, as Sharp (2009) explains, a diplomatic culture is built upon both 'big' and 'small' cultures. It is sourced on the historical and cultural ways of social interactions that are formalised into procedural conduct codes. While there is no specific set of variables to the concept, a diplomatic culture includes practices that constitute practical inter-state relations, such as means of decision making and identification of actors included in it. ES proponents note that diplomatic culture exists in all international political entities. Although states still become the main display for this concept, other actors, such as regional organisations, have also evidently made their own diplomatic culture. They are built as mutually endorsed norms by the society, or members, of the organisation. In the cases of regional organisations, Haacke (2003a) underlines that a distinct diplomatic culture might arise out of particular history and socio-cultural settings and thus provide a different 'way of life' among organisations.

Diplomatic culture is the core pillar of the organisation's existence. First, in internal affairs, diplomatic culture plays a central role in enabling member countries to comply with the agreed norms and implement the respected rules of the organisation. A shared set of norms becomes the member states' cohesion factor. Diplomatic culture demonstrates the collective action of a specific society of states, which in turn is codified as institutional action. We can draw from Haacke's (2003b) work explaining that in times of crisis, diplomatic culture serves as the primary mode and reason for stability for a regional organisation. It provides a roadmap of continuous function and preventing estrangement and insecurity inside the organisation. Second, on external affairs, diplomatic

culture helps member states protect their common interests against penetration from outside players. By following a pre-existing diplomatic culture, member states have a reason to stay and work their differences with non-members. It is made possible by referring to the members' common ground norms (Sharp, 2004). Thus, diplomatic culture generates and conserves a link for continuity and stability from the inside and instils a motivation for society members to prevent crises or resolve problems quickly.

As these two mechanisms function effectively, institutional legitimacy can be saved. Institutional legitimacy refers to 'a general assumption or perception that the institution's behaviour or response to a particular dynamic is appropriate, desirable, or proper in a system of norms, beliefs, values, and definitions built collectively' (Suchman, 1995: 574). The members' perception comes from the substance of the rules and procedures that construct the institution (Hurd, 1999). This perception then influences the individual behaviour because it has been internalised and becomes a reference to view their respective interests against the organisation's common objectives (Clark, 2003). According to Bukovansky (2002: 24), for regional organisations, legitimacy refers 'not to an abstract conception of rights, but rather to the norms of a particular cultural system at a time'. With this in mind, the more members perceive that their regional institution is legitimate, the easier it will be for the latter to obtain resources, make decisions, ensure compliance, and in the end, reduce conflict (Dellmuth et al., 2019). In contrast, regional organisations with less legitimacy will encounter bigger challenges in maintaining their respective regions' existence and roles.

The complex dimension of the crisis

From the beginning of its spread, COVID-19 has brought challenges to the region of Southeast Asia – not only as a health emergency but also within the economic, political and societal dimensions. Chaos due to restricted movement of humans and goods, severe loss in the tourism industry, and supply chain disruption have decreased Southeast Asian countries' economic development. ADB (2022) reports that in 2021, the pandemic pushed 4.7 million Southeast Asians into extreme poverty. It also eliminated 9.3 million jobs in the region. Each regional state uses a different approach to overcome coronavirus infections, whether in lockdowns, quarantines, travel bans or border closures. At the same time, all have introduced various economic stimulus packages to minimise the negative impacts on their national economy. The COVID-19 pandemic has raised serious concerns about how the 10 ASEAN governments collectively deal with non-traditional security issues and several barriers in specific transnational cooperation areas – making the situation more challenging for ASEAN to get through the unsettled time. Myanmar's outbreak of political conflict further adds complexities to the critical juncture to which ASEAN has to respond.

Firstly, after Aung San Suu Kyi's National League for Democracy (NLD) won a significant victory in the 2015 elections and again in the national elections in November 2020, Myanmar faced a rocky road towards democracy. The coup has brought Myanmar to one of its worst periods in the current political climate. The democratic crisis is not only a disaster for the country; it can also signify the continuing regression of democracy in Asia (Kurlantzick, 2021). Southeast Asian states had once made significant improvements towards democratisation. However, it has backslid recently, especially with regression in the former hotspots, including Indonesia, Thailand, Cambodia, the Philippines and Myanmar (Croissant and Haynes, 2021). Individual liberties like freedom of expression, association, and assembly, as well as the independence of the judiciary and media freedom, are all eroded over time by this democratic backsliding process. With the addition of the COVID-19 contagion, this trend has been accelerated. Southeast Asia's fledgling quasi-democracies are under threat from COVID-19, which has challenged the region's socio-political systems, economics, health and development. This is visible

in the attempts to prevent the spreading of the disease, which provide authoritarian leaders with the perfect justification to use harsh measures to repress their opponents and detractors (Hiebert, 2020).

The military in Myanmar utilises COVID-19 to its advantage by abusing authorities it has continued to hold following the reforms, which have strengthened its political clout within the quasi-civilian government. For instance, the military established the powerful COVID-19 task force in late March 2020 to combat disinformation by punishing individuals who incite 'panic among the people' (Hiebert, 2020). The civilian administration functions side by side with this military task force. It assures that the military maintains a prominent position as the nation gets ready for elections before the end of the year. In addition, the army generals have despatched military helicopters to carry medical supplies to outlying areas of the country and set up facilities in important cities to isolate persons infected by the virus. At a broader regional level, the securitisation of the coronavirus, the military's role in crisis management, restrictions on free speech and the press, the demise of democratic institutions, and increased human rights abuses limit the political space available to Southeast Asia's civil society. Most Southeast Asian nations' social distancing laws have made it difficult for opposition politicians to organise protests and severely restricted their communication (Honna, 2020).

The Myanmar crisis is a perfect storm sweeping pluralism and freedom across Southeast Asia. Indonesia and the Philippines are experiencing nostalgia for authoritarianism and democracy fatigue. At the same time, authoritarian consolidation has occurred in several countries, most dramatically in Thailand and Cambodia and even more brutally in Myanmar (Heydarian, 2021). Democratisation is taking a beating around the world. Southeast Asia is experiencing a revival of authoritarianism as part of the region's broader decline and rollback of democratic governance (Beech, 2021).

Secondly, over the years, ASEAN has successfully promoted Southeast Asia as an emerging economic force. However, the Myanmar democratic crisis and the failure to bring a peaceful outcome in Myanmar affected ASEAN's ability to support the member's economic performance. The number of poor people in Myanmar has doubled after more than a decade of hard-won progress in the fight against poverty. Furthermore, the combined consequences of the health and political crises caused millions of people to fall into poverty as the situations were not addressed. UNDP (2021) predicted that more than 26 million people – nearly half of Myanmar's population – would live below the poverty line, the nation's highest level since 2005. The regional community is now witnessing a compounding crisis of unprecedented complexity.

Thirdly, there has been an escalation in violence in Myanmar, particularly after the Junta celebrated Armed Forces Day (AFD) with a military parade, with over 141 citizens reportedly killed across the country. Since 17 February 2021, more than 510 civilians have been confirmed to be killed (AAPPB, 2021). In addition, the Junta has brutally arrested and continued torturing to suppress civil activists. The security forces also routinely commit horrendous crimes, damaging and stealing property, harming citizens, and leaving insecurities within Myanmar communities (Harding and Tower, 2021). Since the beginning of March 2021, tens of thousands of people have left Mandalay and Yangon for other states. In response, ethnic armed groups housing internally displaced people in Kachin and Karen states have been blasted by the *Tatmadaw* Air Force (Eubank, 2021). As the military's reign of terror deepens, thousands of Myanmar residents in border areas seek refuge in India, Thailand, and China. The likelihood of renewed refugee outflows from Myanmar burdened the neighbouring countries. Thousands have already gathered at the Thai borders, raising concerns about the spread of COVID-19. UNHCR (2022) calculated that the number of Myanmar refugees fleeing to other countries had reached over 100 thousands, as well as approximately one million internally displaced persons.

Finally, the Myanmar crisis amid COVID-19 was detrimental to regional cohesion, as it directly impaired the ASEAN collective ability to respond to the brewing geopolitical tensions in Southeast

Asia. At this juncture, ASEAN was distracted as its member states tended to solve their internal problems with a heightened sense of defensiveness and insecurity instead of looking for solutions through regional cooperation. Moreover, this issue made ASEAN even more vulnerable to the great power dynamics that continue to penetrate the region, as politically isolated and economically vulnerable ASEAN countries were at a greater risk of being exploited, especially by China and the United States seeking to overturn the rules-based order (Amador, 2021), in which ASEAN has played a significant role in promoting the regional norms and institutions.

ASEAN's response to the crisis

The international community is vocal in criticising ASEAN and calling for the latter to take concrete action against the Junta in Myanmar. The Myanmar democratic crisis severely violates the principles in the ASEAN Charter and the 2012 ASEAN Declaration of Human Rights, which has alarmed the institution. Human Rights Watch (2022), for example, questions ASEAN's human rights commitment. The foundational principles of ASEAN's self-identity, such as its adherence to 'the ideals of democracy, the rule of law, and good governance, respect for and preservation of human rights and fundamental freedoms', have been challenged by the crisis. Such an inquiry, for instance, was made by the Malaysian Foreign Minister and ASEAN Parliamentarians for Human Rights (2022). Furthermore, the critics (such as Justice for Myanmar, 2022) stated that the hypocrisy within ASEAN leaders' 2015 declaration of an ASEAN Political-Security Community had been revealed. However, ASEAN ignores them. There is no suspension of ASEAN's core state-centric norms of regionalism even when there is an urgent need for collective action because the regional crisis management needs to be more responsive and effective.

ASEAN preserves its old approach to Myanmar. Southeast Asian attitudes to the Myanmar crisis in 1962 and some developments in the coming decades demonstrate two interrelated positions. First, Myanmar has always been important for the regional states. It will continue to be; therefore, ASEAN cannot and will not gamble its diplomatic grip with Myanmar, regardless of domestic politics, nor will it take those situations easy. Second, Myanmar's importance for ASEAN is not based on rationalist considerations such as geopolitics or direct economic flow. Instead, it is a normative one. Myanmar has been shaped and constructed as part of Southeast Asian society, and its entrance to ASEAN in 1997 has further solidified such an idea. ASEAN has always considered regional solidarity and identity building an important part of identity, and the Myanmar situation is a fracture of that identity. Thus, ASEAN cannot suffer an identity crisis, as it will become an institutional cohesion factor for its members.

ASEAN's primary response to the 2021 Myanmar crisis was the emergency summit held on 24 April 2021. The outcome was the five-point consensus. It must be noted that the meeting was also attended by the leader of the coup, Senior General Min Aung Hlaing. The consensus points included: (1) immediate cessation of violence in Myanmar; (2) urging constructive dialogue among all parties; (3) the appointment of a special envoy by ASEAN's chair; (4) ASEAN would be sending humanitarian assistance through ASEAN Coordinating Centre for Humanitarian Assistance on Disaster Management (AHA Centre); and (5) the meeting between ASEAN's special envoy with all parties in a visit to Myanmar.

In its implementation, however, under the rotating chairmanship of Brunei Darussalam, ASEAN was slow in determining the choice for the role of special envoy. It was worsened by the bickering among the member state governments, as they kept proposing national representatives for the position. As a result, the final decision for the job could only be reached in early August 2021, 6 months after the coup (Enos, 2021). Finally, Erywan Yusof, Brunei's Second Minister for Foreign Affairs was approved as the special envoy after a long ministerial meeting (Allard, 2021). Previously,

however, Indonesia's former Foreign Minister Hassan Wirajuda and Thailand's former Deputy Foreign Minister, Virasakdi Futrakul was nominated for the position (The Jakarta Post, 2021). Furthermore, in August of that year, ASEAN (2021) formally pledged humanitarian assistance to Myanmar. ASEAN sought to raise almost 8 million USD in direct monetary aid and medical supplies to Myanmar in the middle of COVID-19 after the World Health Organisation (WHO, 2021) reported more than 10,000 deaths due to coronavirus infections.

ASEAN's unresponsiveness has come at the great price of human security in Myanmar. Until the end of 2021, the military Junta had killed more than 1000 demonstrators and detained more than 5000 political prisoners, including the *de facto* leader of the NLD, Aung San Suu Kyi and Myanmar's President U Win Myint (AAPPB, 2021). ASEAN is the closest and the only regional option available. Nevertheless, these facts do not hinder the organisation from conducting day-to-day business. As mentioned earlier, ASEAN inactions were already perceived by the international community as a symbol of dysfunctionality and hypocrisy towards ASEAN's commitment to human rights and democracy. Moreover, Southeast Asian states neighbouring Myanmar are still under authoritarianism and militarism in their political systems, such as Laos, Cambodia, Vietnam, and Thailand. ASEAN's path-dependent behaviour during the crisis has become an informal precedent for crisis decision making in the future and consolidation for strengthening authoritarianism-militarism in Southeast Asia. This condition is further worsened by the uprisings that are already happening in some ASEAN countries, mainly in Thailand. Still, ASEAN's unhindered business-as-usual attitude to Myanmar is happening in the context of the coronavirus pandemic affecting millions in the region. This situation has not urged a sense of crisis within the ASEAN organisation.

On the contrary, ASEAN remains confident in undertaking its central roles in fostering regional cooperation frameworks such as the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership (RCEP) trade pact, which the bloc's members concluded last in November 2020 with Japan, China, Australia, New Zealand and South Korea, and the ASEAN Regional Forum (ARF) – a rare instance of North Korea taking part in global cooperation. More importantly, ASEAN's failure to resolve the current situation has not posed any existential threat to the institution by decreasing its legitimacy in leading regional affairs and undermining its centrality. It is certainly in contrast to the predictions that ASEAN's underwhelming response to the concerning security issues would reveal the weaknesses embedded in its institution and exposed vulnerabilities within ASEAN that external powers could use to intervene in the region, as expressed, for instance, by Muhibat (2021). How ASEAN has maintained its legitimacy and continuity during the unsettled time is discussed below.

Diplomatic culture securing ASEAN legitimacy

Perceiving ASEAN's diplomatic culture

Over five decades, ASEAN's diplomatic culture has directed the members' intra-Southeast Asian and extra-Southeast Asian relations. Before teasing this out more fully, it is important to say that the evolution of the Association's diplomatic culture has been drawn upon the histories of colonialism that had shaped an important characteristic of the states in the region, called unitary state mentality, meaning that the individual state always considers national sovereignty as unnegotiable (Vatikiotis, 2006). The unitary state mentality manifests in the national struggles to protect national borders from foreign infiltrations, particularly those done by actors from the neighbouring countries. Indeed, all ASEAN members have disputes over unfinished boundaries, accelerated by transnational activities of ethnic groups living in those areas. As a consequence of this continuing issue, Southeast Asians hold mistrust towards each other (Emmers, 2017). Although ideological differences could be put aside, none of the group's state governments wants to submit a significant

part of their national sovereignty to build a cosmopolitan/solidarist supranational organisation like the European Union, making ASEAN works as a pluralist regional society of states (Narine, 2006).

Within the corridor of the pluralist regional society of states, ASEAN's diplomatic culture has been formed, socialised, practised, and developed from various political processes. Beginning in the formation of ASEAN in 1967, the founding members issued a declaration stating that their organisation was governed by the Bandung Principle, the UN Charter, and shared values among Southeast Asian nations. They stressed the importance of cooperation and dialogue instead of conflict and were commited to create peace, stability and prosperity in Southeast Asia (The ASEAN Declaration, 1967). Since then, dialogue has become habitual and practical for ASEAN states. It is also important in attempts to mitigate mistrust among them. There was a moment when Indonesia and Malaysia differed from each other in projecting ASEAN's stance towards the Cold War superpowers' presence in their regional sphere. However, Jakarta and Kuala Lumpur decided to resolve their difference through the ASEAN leaders' informal dialogue. It resulted in the agreement to build ASEAN as a neutral institution in the ideological bloc rivalries. The Zone of Freedom, Peace and Neutrality (ZOFPAN) was announced in 1971 and was affirmed as ASEAN's rejection of the greater states' military power game in Southeast Asia (Zone of Peace, Freedom and Neutrality Declaration, 1971). The Vietnam War and symptoms of disintegration spread in Indonesia, Malaysia and the Philippines due to internal conflicts drove ASEAN to tighten its internal cohesiveness. In 1976, the monumental Treaty of Amity and Cooperation (TAC) was signed and made the main reference to the intra-regional code of conduct.

With the TAC at work, ASEAN applied six components of diplomatic culture: (1) the respect of state sovereignty and national identity, (2) non-interference in members' domestic affairs, (3) the consensus style of decision making, (4) non-use of force to settle interstate disputes, (5) rejection of external states' military activity in ASEAN region and (6) national and regional resilience. In practice, these basic norms have been set and exercised with principles such as equality, flexibility, informality, non-legally binding agreement and consultative manner, also known as ASEAN's secondary norms. In the 1990s, ASEAN began to modify and further expand the scope of application of its diplomatic culture. It happened to respond to the growth of multilateralism in the wider Asia-Pacific geopolitical environment. ASEAN opened its door to formally including the big players as dialogue partners, including China and the United States, in the Association's various cross-regional cooperation schemes. Securing the ASEAN institution, member countries required the non-Southeast Asian ones to adopt the ASEAN TAC before being admitted as partners. The Charter of the ASEAN (2007) enforces the idea that ASEAN is the hub of regionalism developments in its immediate regions of Asia Pacific. Thus, it augments the elements of ASEAN's diplomatic culture to the seventh foundational norm of ASEAN centrality.

ASEAN is maintained by mitigating the mistrust effect that could delegitimise the regional cooperation institution. In this context, however, the ASEAN institutional legitimacy must be secured from the distraction of security issues, either related to state or non-state causes. Hence, ASEAN leaders remind each other of the need for self-restraint when an insecurity problem is exasperating. Historically, security threats stemming from the spillover of the members' domestic crisis have been more challenging to ASEAN than those from military aggression from non-Southeast Asian powers. At the same time, the state's national security capacity to manage the insecurities is quite limited and, from a comparative perspective, is not balanced, affecting ASEAN's collective security governance resources. So it is understandable if, in dealing with the critical juncture caused by COVID-19 and the Myanmar democratic crisis, ASEAN legitimacy was maintained by intangible means, that is, its diplomatic culture, comprising two essential mechanisms: ensuring compliance of all members with the ASEAN code of conduct and preventing external intrusion in intra-regional affairs, helping ASEAN to continue to pursue its crucial regional roles (Ba, 2013).

Ensuring member states' compliance with the ASEAN code of conduct

The multidimensional aspects of COVID-19 and Myanmar's political conflict urged ASEAN states to return to their primary norms and follow the secondary ones to keep all comply with the former. The national-centric approach to handling the pandemic had placed the regional institution almost at the margin of the arena. The most affected countries, like Indonesia, Malaysia, Singapore, Thailand and the Philippines, preferred to seek assistance from their non-ASEAN partners through bilateral or multilateral channels. For instance, the ASEAN Plus Three (China, Japan and South Korea) Foreign Ministers' meeting held through video conference on 9 September 2020 exposed Southeast Asians' dependence on their more developed East Asian counterparts. The virtual gathering stated that the ASEAN Plus Three would focus on two urgent agendas: vaccine development, production, distribution and post-pandemic economic recovery (Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the Republic of Indonesia, 2020). ASEAN members recharged their internal cohesion to follow up on this outcome. First, ASEAN must prepare for its regional arrangements to implement crisis management strategies. Second, the domestic interests of the member countries should be protected, despite their lack of 'self-help' ability.

Tightening the grip on ASEAN's norms was even more desirable when the military coup in Myanmar brought about additional unwanted problems for the Association. The other nine member countries were making strenuous efforts to recover their economy, suppressed by the pandemic, and the political crisis in Myanmar disrupted them. ASEAN leaders believe that economic development is determined by political stability. As a result, the region must be kept as stable as possible to allow the economic sector to move productively. ASEAN could not disregard the Myanmar factor for regional stability. The feasible option to deal with Myanmar was to approach the Junta using the old and established ASEAN Way. ASEAN undertook a 'soft pressure' mechanism on Myanmar, done in a dialogue format. ASEAN experiences with norm socialisation show that it is more successful through informal methods, instead of formal approaches like imposing sanctions on the troubled member. Recently, informality has been influential in the ASEAN's response to the Rohingya genocide (Rosyidin and Dir, 2021). ASEAN might wish to avoid more complicated political instability, social disorder and economic turmoil in Myanmar if the country were isolated or sanctioned.

ASEAN confines its responsibility to resolve the Myanmar internal conflict only by facilitating dialogue among the conflicting parties and not mediating or deeply intervening in the conflict. ASEAN lets the conflicting parties find solutions for their problems. This approach has been taken to various domestic conflicts among the members. A higher degree of ASEAN involvement in the peace process was undertaken only when the internal conflict broadened into an inter-state one. For example, during the civil war in Cambodia in the 1980s. In this situation, too, ASEAN was cautious in proposing its problem-solving formula. It would not contain anything considered interference, such as direct military action, regime change support and membership suspension. Many have encouraged ASEAN to suspend or even kick Myanmar out of the group. But, ASEAN does not do that. Although the Junta leader has been uninvited to ASEAN summits since the end of 2021, Myanmar remains to be represented by its non-military and non-political officials in the cycle of ASEAN activities. This practice of diplomacy is a middle-way consensus reached to save ASEAN unity amid the disagreement on how to respond to the Myanmar crisis. The more democratic Indonesia, Malaysia, the Philippines and Singapore are critical of the Junta, while the rest are silent. An uncompromising stance on Myanmar will enlarge the difference between them. Of course, ASEAN does not want it. Alternatively, flexibility to save face is practical.

Many are disappointed with ASEAN. However, as the Association's long-standing motto says Southeast Asian solutions for Southeast Asia, ASEAN does its way. The style and content of ASEAN diplomacy matter in keeping the group's reputation internally. None of the member

countries has ever expressed any grievance of misconduct in ASEAN's dealing with the crisis. All agree to prioritise the sustainability of the regional institution. Standing by the ASEAN norms, principles and values is a significant path to chasing common objectives. ASEAN can continue to work on its agreed projects to build a Southeast Asian community, encompassing economic, political, security and socio-cultural fields of cooperation. Although COVID-19 and Myanmar conflict have disturbed them, ASEAN does not stop. The 40th ASEAN Summit on 11 November 2022 demonstrates that there is confidence among the group's leaders that they can maintain ASEAN's regional roles as everyone commits to work towards their priority areas (ASEAN Summit, 2022).

Preventing external intrusion in intra-regional affairs

As mentioned, ASEAN is accustomed to facing great power rivalries, from the Cold War to the recent China–US competition. To some extent, China–Japan is vying for regional leadership, which has shaped Southeast Asian security architecture. The impacts of the extra-regional states' contests were pressing enough for ASEAN during COVID-19. In the first 6 months of the global pandemic, domestic political dynamics in Beijing and Washington were unfavourably extended towards East Asia through China–US confrontational military interaction in the South China Sea, heating up the waters' geopolitics. At the same time, China and Japan tried to use the critical moment to proceed with their deepened bilateral engagement with ASEAN. The rival power politics intensified as China, Japan and the United States competed for vaccine diplomacy. Since the Myanmar democratic collapse has come out as an international issue, ASEAN tried to isolate it from the outsiders' interference, mainly because the Junta was backed by China but opposed by the United States.

There were sporadic events over the 2010s when ASEAN members failed to make a solid response to China's increasingly assertive behaviour. Washington perceived these as a gesture of weakening ASEAN cohesiveness and centrality so that the US' larger strategic presence in the region was inevitable to rebalance Beijing's growing influence. In response, ASEAN appealed to the competing powers to strengthen their commitment to implementing the agreed norms of relations in Southeast Asia. ASEAN refused the stronger states' offers to heighten bilateral cooperation. Instead, they must be built upon a multilateral one (Yoshimatsu, 2022), in which ASEAN is the driver. Amid COVID-19 and Myanmar's political turmoil, ASEAN kept promoting its Indo-Pacific outlook to other regional actors that expanded their respective formulations. In particular, Japan and the United States have fostered a Free and Open Indo-Pacific (FOIP) against the Chinese Belt and Road Initiative (BRI).

The ASEAN Outlook on the Indo-Pacific (AOIP) proposes to build a rules-based order in which ASEAN's values, norms, principles and practices are transplanted into the broader relationships of Asia-Pacific and Indian Ocean countries. Initially, when the AOIP was first announced in 2019, China objected to the term Indo-Pacific, regarding it as a new strategic construct of the US alliance to block China's progress. On the contrary, Washington sent an approval message to the AOIP, saying it had similarities with the FOIP essential objectives to create an inclusive, open, secure and stable maritime Indo-Pacific order (ASEAN-United States Summit, 2019). However, Japan and the United States utilised the FOIP initiative as the basis to revive the 2007 Quadrilateral Security Dialogue (Quad), a military alignment consisting of Australia, India, Japan and the United States. ASEAN was not comfortable with the Quad activity. However, as military tensions between China and the United States blocs increased in 2020 and 2021, along with the COVID-19 pandemic economic crisis, ASEAN enhanced diplomacy to approach the two sides to accept its Indo-Pacific proposal, especially on the point of a non-militarised zone.

ASEAN's diplomacy made positive outcomes. The 9th ASEAN-US summit on 26 October 2021 came out with a joint commitment to improving cooperation in the health, climate, science, education and trade sectors (ASEAN-United States Summit, 2021). Later in May 2022, ASEAN and the United

States affirmed the synergy between AOIP and FOIP. More importantly, President Joe Biden's administration sees the importance of supporting ASEAN centrality and unity for achieving the Indo-Pacific maritime order. In parallel, in the ASEAN–China summit on 22 November 2021, the Chinese government was willing to accept the AOIP and stated to favour ASEAN's peaceful order-builder role in the Indo-Pacific (ASEAN-China Summit, 2021). The success of these diplomatic processes led by ASEAN demonstrates that the group's consistency with its established norms and values can generate a favourable atmosphere amid the contested and uncertain regional environment. It keeps the contesting great powers focusing more on the common objective of creating order instead of penetrating ASEAN's claimed domestic affairs like the Myanmar political conflict. ASEAN's ability to exploit its diplomatic culture's elements helps secure the organisation's legitimacy as the central regional institution in the Indo-Pacific. No need for ASEAN to change anything due to the critical situation.

Conclusion

The HI and ES theoretical framework combination can explain the missing part of ASEAN's response to the critical juncture of COVID-19 and Myanmar's political crisis. As underlined at the beginning of the article, HI-based analysis provides a valuable starting point from which it is worth undertaking a further inquiry into ASEAN's decision to return to its foundational ideas and practices in dealing with the current unsettled situation. To this end, we draw upon the link between diplomatic culture and institutional legitimacy, taken from the ES scholarship. In the ASEAN case, diplomatic culture has evolved around seven basic norms and some procedural principles applicable to support the regional organisation in its important roles. As a result, ASEAN does not need to change despite the external shock and pressure mandate it. This is because the institution's diplomatic culture helps direct all members to comply with their shared norms, values and principles. In addition, ASEAN's diplomatic culture enables members to prevent extra-regional players' intrusion in the crisis.

By employing diplomatic culture-institutional legitimacy, we can look more analytically at how and why ASEAN chooses to return to its standard instruments and methods to cope with the critical moment. ASEAN members followed its old and established ideas and rules to secure their common interest of maintaining regional political stability for economic development. About the geopolitical dynamics spurred by great power rivalries, ASEAN must keep its region free, safe and neutral from the dividing politics of China and the US contestation. Thus, the regional organisation must embrace the competing powers in its norms-based multilateral relationships, not the particular material-based bilateral ones. Having done these, ASEAN can legitimise its position as the core institution of regionalism in Southeast Asia and the broader Indo-Pacific. With all this in mind, the authors would say that thinking and working within an eclectic HI and ES have led to more effective and significant explanations of a crucial phase of an institution's development.

Funding

The authors received no financial support for the research, authorship, and/or publication of this article.

ORCID iD

I Gede Wahyu Wicaksana https://orcid.org/0000-0002-0224-8400

References

AAPPB (2021) Torture to Death in Detention. Available at https://aappb.org/?p=15746 (accessed 18 August 2021).
ADB (2022) COVID-19 Pushed 4.7 Million More People in Southeast Asia into Extreme Poverty in 2021, but Countries are Well Positioned to Bounce Back — ADB 16 March. Available at https://www.adb.org/

news/covid-19-pushed-4-7-million-more-people-southeast-asia-extreme-poverty-2021-countries-are-well (accessed 3 December 2022).

Allard T (2021) ASEAN Appoints Brunei Diplomat as Envoy to Myanmar. *Reuters*, 4 August Available at https://www.reuters.com/world/asia-pacific/asean-appoints-bruneis-erywan-yusof-envoy-myanmar-sources-2021-08-04/ (accessed 7 September 2021).

Amador JS (2021) The Continuing Erosion of ASEAN Centrality. *ASEAN Focus* 36. Singapore: ISEAS-Yusof Ishak Institute.

Amaya A and De Lombaerde P (2021) Regional cooperation is essential to combating health emergencies in the Global South. *Globalization and Health* 17(9): 2–6.

ASEAN (2021) Close to USD 8 Million in Pledges Raised to Support ASEAN's Humanitarian Assistance in Myanmar. 18 August. Available at https://asean.org/close-to-usd8-million-in-pledges-raised-to-support-aseans-humanitarian-assistance-in-myanmar/ (accessed 7 August 2021).

ASEAN Parliamentarians for Human Rights (2022) Malaysian Foreign Minister and international parliamentarians demand stronger action on Myanmar 19 September. Available at https://aseanmp.org/2022/09/19/malaysian-foreign-minister-and-international-parliamentarians-demand-stronger-action-on-myanmar/ (accessed 3 December 2022).

ASEAN Summit (2022) ASEAN Leaders' Declaration on Mainstreaming Four Priority Areas of the ASEAN Outlook on the Indo-Pacific Within ASEAN-Led Mechanisms. Phnom Penh: 40th ASEAN Summit.

ASEAN-China Summit (2021) Joint Statement of the ASEAN-China Special Summit to Commemorate the 30th Anniversary of ASEAN-China Dialogue Relations: Comprehensive Strategic Partnership for Peace, Security, Prosperity and Sustainable Development. Jakarta: ASEAN Secretariat.

ASEAN-United States Summit (2019) Chairman's Statement of the 7th ASEAN-United States Summit. Bangkok: 7th ASEAN-United States Summit.

ASEAN-United States Summit (2021) Chairman's Statement of the 9th ASEAN-United States Summit. Brunei Darussalam: 9th ASEAN-United States Summit.

Ba AD (2013) The association of Southeast Asian nations: Between internal and external legitimacy. In: Zaum D (ed) *Legitimating International Organizations*. Oxford: Oxford University Press, pp. 132–161.

Beech H (2021) Myanmar Coup puts the Seal on Autocracy's Rise in Southeast *New York Times*, 12 April. Available at https://www.nytimes.com/2021/04/12/world/asia/myanmar-coup-autocracy-democracy.html (accessed 7 September 2021).

Bukovansky M (2002) *Legitimacy and Power Politics: The American and French Revolutions in International Political Culture*. Princeton: Princeton University Press.

Bull H (1977) *The Anarchical Society: A Study of Order in World Politics.,* Fourth Edition. London: Palgrave Macmillan.

Capoccia G (2015) Critical junctures and institutional change. In: Mahoney J and Thelen K (eds) *Advances in Comparative Historical Analysis*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, pp. 147–179.

Capoccia G and Kelemen RD (2007) The study of critical junctures: Theory, narrative and counterfactuals in institutional theory. *World Politics* 59(3): 341–369.

Charter of the Association of Southeast Asian Nations (2007).

Clark I (2003) Legitimacy in global order. *Review of International Studies* 29: 75–95.

Cook ADB (2010) Positions of responsibility: A comparison of ASEAN and EU approaches towards Myanmar. *International Politics* 47(3–4): 433–449.

Croissant A and Haynes J (2021) Democratic regression in Asia: Introduction. *Democratisation* 28(2): 1–21.

David PA (2007) Path dependence: A foundational concept for historical social science. *Cliometrica* 1(2): 91–114.

Dellmuth LM, Jan AS and Jonas T (2019) Institutional sources of legitimacy for international organisations: Beyond procedure versus performance. *Review of International Studies* 45(4): 627–646.

Emmers R (2017) Enduring mistrust and conflict management in Southeast Asia: An assessment of ASEAN as a security community. *TRaNS: Trans-Regional and -National Studies of Southeast Asia* 5(1): 75–97.

Enos O (2021) ASEAN'S Response to Myanmar Coup is Failing *The Heritage Foundation*, 23 July. Available at https://www.heritage.org/asia/commentary/aseans-response-myanmar-coup-failing (accessed 7 September 2021).

Eubank D (2021) Interview: 'I Haven't Seen Airstrikes in Karen State For Over 20 Years. *RFA* Available at https://www.rfa.org/english/news/myanmar/rangers-03312021191818.html (accessed 18 Augustus 2021).

Haacke J (2003a) *ASEAN's Diplomatic and Security Culture: Origins, Development and Prospects*. London: Routledge.

Haacke J (2003b) ASEAN's diplomatic and security culture: A constructivist assessment. *International Relations of the Asia-Pacific* 3(1): 57–87.

Haacke J (2005) Enhanced interaction with Myanmar and the project of a security community: Is ASEAN refining or breaking with its diplomats and security culture? *Contemporary Southeast Asia* 27(2): 188–216.

Hanung CD and Judhistari RA (2021) One Vision, Different Responses: An Analysis of ASEAN Member States' Responses to the Myanmar Coup and Recommendations. Policy Brief. Bangkok: FORUM-ASIA.

Harding B and Tower J (2021) Myanmar Coup Weakens Southeast Asia Security and Cooperation. *USIP*. Available at https://www.usip.org/publications/2021/04/myanmar-coup-weakens-southeast-asia-security-and-cooperation (accessed 18 Augustus 2021).

Heydarian R (2021) Myanmar Coup Reveals Urgent Need for ASEAN Overhaul. Nikkei Asia. Available at https://asia.nikkei.com/Opinion/Myanmar-coup-reveals-urgent-need-for-ASEAN-overhaul (accessed 21 August 2021).

Hiebert M (2020) COVID-19 Threatens Democracy in Southeast Asia. East Asia Forum Available at https://www.eastasiaforum.org/2020/05/25/covid-19-threatens-democracy-in-southeast-asia/ (accessed 21 August 2021).

Honna J (2020) Military politics in pandemic Indonesia. *The Asia-Pacific Journal* 18(5): 1–9.

Human Rights Watch (2022) ASEAN: Act to Stop Myanmar Military Abuses. 1 November. Available at https://www.hrw.org/news/2022/11/01/asean-act-stop-myanmar-military-abuses (accessed 3 December 2022).

Hurd I (1999) Legitimacy and authority in international politics. *International Organization* 53(2): 379–408.

Justice for Myanmar (2022) ASEAN's Complicity in the Myanmar Military's Atrocity Crime. 10 May. Available at https://www.justiceformyanmar.org/stories/aseans-complicity-in-the-myanmar-militarys-atrocity-crimes (accessed 3 December 2022).

Katanyuu R (2006) Beyond non-interference in ASEAN: The association's role in Myanmar's national reconciliation and democratisation. *Asian Survey* 46(6): 825–845.

Kurlantzick J (2021) Myanmar's Coup Emblematic of Regional Democracy Failures. Council of Foreign Relations. Available at https://www.cfr.org/blog/myanmars-coup-emblematic-regional-democracy-failures (accessed 21 August 2021).

Mahoney J (2001) Path dependent explanations of regime change: Central America in comparative perspective. *Studies in Comparative International Development* 36(1): 111–141.

Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the Republic of Indonesia (2020) 21st ASEAN Plus Three Foreign MInisters' Meeting via Video Conference, 9 September 2020. Available at https://kemlu.go.id/portal/en/read/1668/berita/21st-asean-plus-three-foreign-ministers-meeting-via-video-conference-9-september-2020 (accessed 3 December 2022).

Muhibat S (2021) *Embracing Change to Stay Resilient. ASEAN Focus 36*. Singapore: ISEAS-Yusof Ishak Institute.

Narine S (2006) The English school and ASEAN. *The Pacific Review* 19(2): 199–218.

Paulsen E (2021) ASEAN must Facilitate Myanmar's Return to Democracy. *The Jakarta Post*, 20 February. Available at https://www.thejakartapostcom/academia/2021/02/19/asean-must-facilitate-myanmars-return-to-democracy.html (accessed 7 September 2021).

Pradhan SK (2008) Struggle for democracy in Myanmar: Response of neighbours, United States and ASEAN. *Jadavpur Journal of International Relations* 11–12(1): 228–241.

Quayle L (2013) *Southeast Asia and the English School of International Relations: A Region-Theory Dialogue*. London: Palgrave Macmillan.

Renshaw CS (2013) Democratic transformation and regional institutions: The case of Myanmar and ASEAN. *Journal of Current Southeast Asian Affairs* 32(1): 29–54.

Rixen T and Viola LA (2015) Putting path dependence in its place: Toward a taxonomy of institutional change. *Journal of Theoretical Politics* 27(2): 301–323.

Rixen T, Viola LA and Zürn M (2016) *Historical Institutionalism and International Relations*. Oxford: Oxford University Press.

Rosyidin M and Dir AAB (2021) Why states do not impose sanctions: Regional norms and Indonesia's diplomatic approach towards Myanmar on the Rohingya issue. *International Politics* 58(5): 738–756.

Ruland J (2021) COVID-19 and ASEAN: Strengthening state-centrism, eroding inclusiveness, testing cohesion. *Italian Journal of International Affairs* 56(2): 72–92.

Sharp P (2004) The idea of diplomatic culture and its sources. In: Slavik H (ed) *Intercultural Communication and Diplomacy*. Geneva: Diplofoundation, pp. 361–379.

Sharp P (2009) *Diplomatic Theory of International Relations*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press. London: SAGE.

Suchman M (1995) Managing legitimacy: Strategic and institutional approaches. *Academy of Management Review* 20(3): 571–610.

The ASEAN Declaration (Bangkok Declaration) (1967).

The Jakarta Post (2021) ASEAN Deadlocked in Selection of Special Envoy to Myanmar, 6 July. Available at https://www.thejakartapostcom/seasia/2021/07/06/asean-deadlocked-in-selection-of-special-envoy-to-myanmar.html (accessed 7 September, 2021).

Treaty of Amity and Cooperation in Southeast Asia (1976).

UNDP/United Nations Development Program (2021) COVID-19, Coup d'Etat and Poverty: Compounding Negative Shocks and Their Impact on Human Development in Myanmar UNDP Report. Available at https://reliefweb.int/sites/reliefweb.int/files/resources/UNDP-RBAP-COVID-19-Coup-d-Etat-and-Poverty-Impact-on-Myanmar-2021.pdf (accessed 20 August 2021).

UNHCR (2022) Myanmar Situation. Available at https://reporting.unhcr.org/myanmarsituation (accessed 3 December 2022).

Vatikiotis M (2006) Resolving Internal Conflicts in Southeast Asia: Domestic Challenges and Regional Perspectives. *Contemporary Southeast Asia*, pp. 27–47.

WHO (2021) COVID-19, Myanmar Situation. Available at https://covid19.who.int/region/searo/country/mm (accessed 8 September 2021).

Yoshimatsu H (2022) ASEAN and great power rivalry in regionalism: From East Asia to the Indo-Pacific. *Journal of Current Southeast Asian Affairs*.

Zone of Peace, Freedom and Neutrality Declaration (1971).